

World Health Organization (WHO) Guidelines on Infant & Toddler Feeding

Clinical Nutrition and Dietary Safety Standards for Ages 6 to 24 Months

1. Core Principles of Safe Complementary Feeding

Complementary feeding begins at 6 months when breast milk or formula alone is no longer sufficient to meet nutritional requirements. Foods must be nutrient-dense, easily digestible, and prepared under strict sanitary conditions.

2. Prohibited and Unsafe Ingredients for Infants (< 12 Months)

- **Honey:** STRICTLY PROHIBITED for all infants under 12 months due to the severe risk of infant botulism caused by *Clostridium botulinum* spores.
- **Added Sugars:** No added sugars, syrups, confectionery, or sweetened beverages. High sugar intake alters taste preferences and damages developing dental health.
- **Excessive Salt and Sodium:** Infant kidneys cannot process high sodium loads. Keep daily salt intake below 1g/day. Processed potato chips, salty snacks, and canned foods are unsafe.
- **Cow's Milk as Primary Drink:** Unmodified cow's milk should not replace formula or breast milk before 12 months as it lacks sufficient iron and has excessive protein.
- **Caffeine & Cocoa (Chocolate):** Chocolate contains theobromine and caffeine, which cause cardiovascular stimulation, gastrointestinal distress, and sleep disturbances in babies.

3. Highly Recommended Starter Foods for Babies (6-12 Months)

- **Banana:** 100% natural, smooth texture when mashed. Rich in potassium, vitamin B6, and prebiotic fiber. Easily digested and gentle on infant digestive tracts.
- **Sweet Potatoes & Squash:** Steamed and pureed. Excellent source of Vitamin A, beta-carotene, and natural carbohydrates.
- **Oatmeal & Iron-Fortified Grains:** Soft porridge supporting crucial brain and nervous system development.
- **Avocado:** Healthy monounsaturated fatty acids crucial for rapid neurodevelopment.